



THE GUARDIANS OF ELARIA

SESSION 1

The Gathering of Friends

An illustrated adventure. Read the gold boxes aloud; the purple boxes are for the DM.

Our Story Begins



Eldridge Village at dusk, where our story begins.

Far to the west, in a land called **Eldridge Vale**, the hills roll green and soft, and the roads wind between hedgerows and sleepy farms. Folk here live quiet lives. They mend fences, bake bread, and tell stories by the fire. But lately the stories have changed. Travelers speak of glowing creatures slipping between the trees of the **Forest of Whispers**, of winds that seem to murmur words, of lights where no lantern burns.

The old tales say the world is only one of many: that other realms turn beside ours like the wheels of a great clock, close enough to touch in the thin places. For a thousand years the

clock has kept perfect time. Tonight, in a little village at the edge of a whispering wood, something slips.

Three young heroes are about to meet. None of them knows it yet, but the stars themselves have been waiting for this evening.

► The heroes begin this chronicle at **level 3**. Full creature statistics for every session live in the compendium; a DM run sheet and bestiary close each session.



Eldridge Vale and the lands of Elaria, as mapped by the cartographers of Gearhaven.

Part One: The Gilded Acorn

The **Gilded Acorn Tavern** is the heart of Eldridge Village: a warm, golden room that smells of roasting meat and fresh bread. Wooden beams cross the ceiling, hunting trophies and faded banners line the walls, and a great stone hearth crackles against the evening chill. A minstrel strums a lute on the little stage in the corner. The tavern is crowded tonight, and every table hums with the same uneasy talk: the forest, the lights, the whispers.



The Gilded Acorn Tavern, the heart of Eldridge Village.

Behind the bar stands **Osric the innkeeper**, broad shouldered and bushy bearded, his laugh booming over the noise. Between tables darts **Rhea the barmaid**, quick handed and quicker witted, hearing every rumor in the room twice before anyone finishes telling it.

► **Eldridge Village.** Small but lively. Besides the Gilded Acorn, heroes can visit **Garrick's Forge** (blacksmith), **Evelyn's Remedies** (herbalist), **The Wandering Trinket** (general store), and the **Weary Wanderer Inn**. Osric and Rhea are the rumor sources; both point toward the Forest of Whispers.



Lilly's Arrival

The tavern door opens on a traveler unlike any Eldridge has seen: a deep gnome girl, small even for her folk, with skin like polished slate, long silver hair, and striking red eyes. **Lilly Glimmergear** has walked a long way from **Deepforge Hollow**, and the surface world is almost too much: too bright, too loud, too wonderfully strange. She clutches a brass and crystal device to her chest, a sphere that hums softly, like something inside it is dreaming.

Her mother, the tinkerer **Poots Glimmergear**, pressed the **Essence Sphere** into her hands before she left. Inside it sleeps the spark of a creature called **Pikachu**, an old friend trapped without a body. *Find Ursa Catchum*, her mother said. *The son of my old adventuring companion. If anyone can help you wake our friend, it is that family.*

Osric: “Ursa, you say? Odd lad, that one. Can usually be found star gazing out in the fields, or else wandering the woods. If you are looking for him, best sit tight and wait. He comes around often enough.”

So Lilly finds a small table by the fire, sets the Sphere gently in her lap, and waits, excited and nervous all at once, wondering what kind of person this Ursa will be.

Ursa's Curiosity

Outside the village, a red haired boy lies back in the cool grass, tracing constellations as they wake in the darkening sky. **Ursa Catchum** knows the stars the way other children know their own street. His father, the renowned wildfire druid **Ash Catchum**, disappeared when Ursa was young, leaving behind three enchanted potatoes, a thousand questions, and a boy who watches the sky as if it might answer them. The **Circle of the Eternal Stars** raised him after that, and taught him to listen to the world's quiet voices.

Tonight the quiet voices are not quiet. There is a hum in the air, a shiver in the natural flow of things, and when word reaches him that a stranger is asking for him by name, Ursa is already walking toward the village. Some part of him, the part his father left him, knows: something is beginning.



In the tavern, Ursa spots the silver haired gnome girl at once, and the strange contraption glowing faintly in her lap. He crosses the room, cautious and curious in equal measure.

Ursa: “Are you looking for me?”

Lilly: “Yes! I am Lilly. And I believe you can help me with... this.” She lifts the Essence Sphere. As Ursa leans close, he feels the familiar pull of living magic, but unlike any creature or energy he has ever met. Something is in there. Something waiting.

Stabby's Grand Entrance

BANG. The tavern door slams open hard enough to rattle the trophies on the walls.

In struts a goblin boy with green skin, light green hair, sharp little teeth, and red eyes lit with

pure mischief. **Stabby Sharpblade**, seven years old and afraid of absolutely nothing, surveys the room like a king inspecting his castle.

Stabby was born to the **Bloodfang Clan** in far off **Bloodthorn Hollow**, where goblin children learn to be quick or learn to be sorry. A wandering monk, **Master Kaelon Windstep** of the Whispering Breeze, taught him balance, patience (a little), and gave him his name. Then the road called, and Stabby followed it here, bored and hungry for excitement.

◆ LORE OF ELARIA ◆ **The Whispering Breeze Monastery**

High in the passes stands a monastery whose monks study the oldest wind, the one that has been circling the world since the Weaving. They say every storm is just that wind remembering something. Their teaching is short: when the whole world is screaming, get still.



He notices the glowing sphere immediately. He notices the two interesting strangers around it immediately after. He invites himself to their table before either can say a word.

Stabby: “Oi! You two look like you are planning an adventure!” He plops down, grinning. Lilly startles; Ursa only raises an eyebrow. Lilly explains her quest, the Sphere, the sleeping spark inside. Stabby understands maybe half of it, and cares about exactly none of that half.

Stabby: “I do not know what that is. But it looks important. And if there is adventure involved, count me in!”

Rumors and a Brawl

Osric brings mugs and news to the new table of three. All around them the tavern murmurs: *old Jarek saw something glowing in the woods again... strange winds out there... the trees do not sound right... folk say the forest is waking up.*

Osric, leaning in low: “There has been talk of creatures in the forest. Magical ones. Folk say they do not belong here, like they wandered in from... somewhere else.”

Rhea, setting down a tray: “A traveler last night swore he saw something with glowing eyes by the pond. Did not stay to get a closer look. Cannot say I blame him.”

Before the three can trade theories, a shadow falls across their table. **Bren**, a burly local several drinks past sensible, cracks his knuckles and grins down at them.

Bren: “Oi! You lot look like you think you are tough. How about you prove it? A little friendly brawl, eh?”

► **The brawl.** Bren (AC 12, HP 8, unarmed strike +3 for 1d4 + 1) and two friends (AC 11, HP 6, unarmed +3 for 1d4): fists, chairs, and one regrettable mug, strictly non lethal. Heroes who try to wave Bren off only make him louder; soon he and his friends are standing over the table, and the fight comes to them. They rely on brute force, ganging up on one or two heroes at a time, and Osric steps in if things get too hot. Any hero knocked down wakes a minute later with a bruised ear and a mug of cider on the house. The three strangers fight together for the first time, and win.



A little friendly brawl, and the first fight the three ever won together.

It is short, loud, and glorious. Stabby fights like a rumor: everywhere and nowhere. Lilly's gadgets spark and startle. Ursa never even stands up all the way. When Bren finally sits down hard, rubbing his jaw, the whole tavern is laughing, and so, almost, is he.

Bren: “Agh... fine. Maybe you are tougher than you look.”

Osric claps his hands over the noise. “Alright, that is enough! Bren, leave these folks alone before I toss you out!” He sets a fresh round before the three young strangers, on the house. “Sorry about that. But I can see you lot handle yourselves. If you are heading into the forest, you will need that strength. There are more dangerous things out there than Bren, I promise you that. Something is stirring near the Forest of Whispers. And it is not just the wind.”

Three strangers walked into the Gilded Acorn tonight. It is a party of adventurers that walks out, under a sky thick with watching stars.

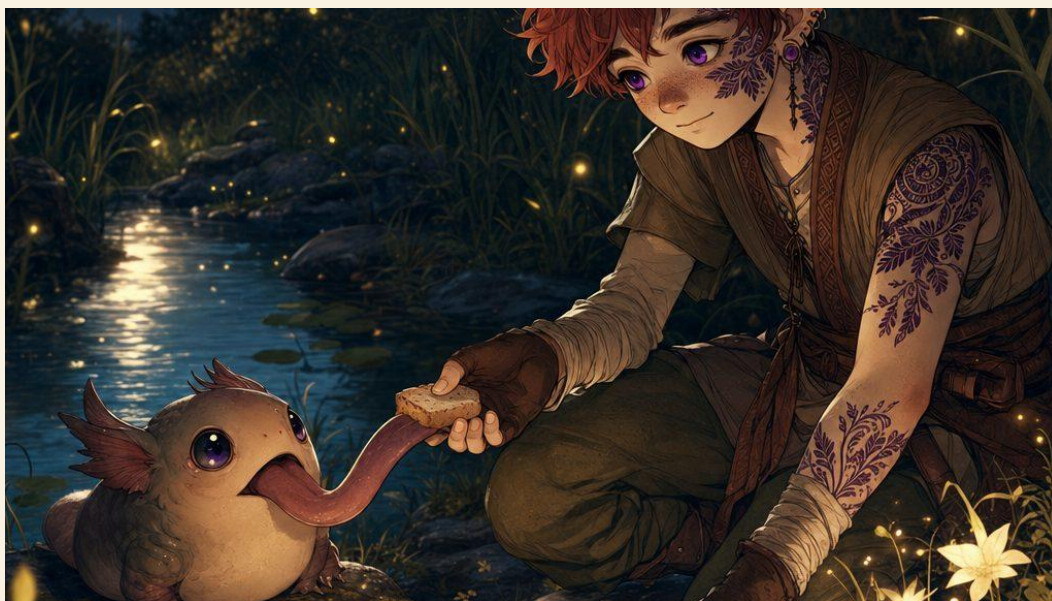
Part Two: The Whispering Pond

The new friends left the warm noise of the tavern behind and followed the path toward the forest, drawn by rumor and the glow of adventure.

Beyond the last cottages, the night turns soft and silver. Mist rolls in from the treeline, and the path bends past a small pond ringed with reeds and wildflowers. The water holds the starlight strangely, glowing faintly from below, and here the air shivers, as though the world's fabric is worn thin as old cloth.

► **Wisdom (Perception) DC 12** to spot a glimmering light moving in the reeds; on a failure the heroes hear only rustling reeds and frogs, and Lickgloom shows itself when they reach the water's edge.

Something small is moving at the water's edge. It is round bodied, about the size of a halfling, with faintly shimmering skin, enormous curious eyes, and a tongue longer than it is tall, which flicks out to taste the pond, then a wildflower, then the air in the party's direction. Around it the reeds sway toward it like friends leaning in, and the colors of the night seem brighter, dreamlike, wherever it goes.



The Whispering Pond, where the water holds the starlight strangely.

This is **Lickgloom**, a creature of the **Feywild**, a realm of wild wonder that presses close against our own. It did not break into the world. It simply wandered through a door that should not have been open.

► **Meeting Lickgloom.** Wisdom (Insight) DC 10: curious and playful, not a threat. Wisdom (Animal Handling) DC 12 to befriend with food and patience; on a failure, or at any aggression, it darts into the pond and hides. Intelligence (Arcana) DC 14: creature and pond both hum with Feywild energy; the boundary between planes is worn thin here. If it flees, searching the bank finds wildflowers blooming out of season and strange ripples (same Arcana check to read them), and quiet patience plus a snack coaxes it back out. The party offered bread, and succeeded.

Lickgloom pads closer, tilting its head. When Ursa kneels and holds out a bit of bread, the long tongue snaps out, the bread vanishes, and a feeling arrives in everyone's minds at once, wordless and warm: *Food? Friend?*

Friend. The little fey creature falls in beside the party, flicking its tongue at fireflies, and just like that the three heroes become four travelers. All around the pond, where Lickgloom passed, the wildflowers are blooming out of season.

► **Lickgloom, companion.** Traveling with the party, Lickgloom can fetch small objects with its 10 foot tongue, and once per scene its tasting tongue grants one hero advantage on a Wisdom (Perception) or Intelligence (Investigation) check. Statistics in the appendix.

Part Three: The Forest of Whispers

With Lickgloom trotting alongside, the party stepped beneath the eaves of the forest everyone in Eldridge Vale had warned them about.

The Forest of Whispers earns its name at once. The canopy closes overhead until the starlight comes through in coins and slivers, and the wind moving in the leaves makes a long, low murmur, like a crowd whispering just out of sight. The mist thickens around your boots. The air feels charged, the way it does before a storm breaks.



Beneath the eaves of the Forest of Whispers, where the starlight comes through in coins and slivers.

◆ LORE OF ELARIA ◆ The First Listeners

Before there were villages there were listeners. The first druids did not learn magic; they learned quiet, and the forests, glad of the company, taught them the rest. The Circle of the Eternal Stars still opens every gathering with a full minute of silence, in honor of the age when that was the whole religion.

The Stone Circle and the Duck with the Leek

The trees open into a wide clearing where five towering stones stand in a rough ring, mossy and carved with runes too old to read. The air above them ripples like heat over a summer road. And perched atop the tallest stone, silhouetted against the sky, stands a bird.

It is a large, sturdy duck. It is holding a leek like a sword. Its eyes glow with a pale light, and the wind in the clearing moves when it moves, swirling leaves in slow spirals around the stones. A voice arrives in your minds, sharp as a whistle: a telepathic *quack*.



Duckleaf: “Intruders! Leave this place... or face the winds!”

► **The stone circle.** Intelligence (Arcana) or Wisdom (Nature) DC 14: the five stones are amplifying elemental air energy; the creature draws its power from the **Elemental Plane of Air**. Damaging or disrupting one stone breaks that connection: Duckleaf loses its Winged Leap for the rest of the battle, and it defends the stones fiercely once it realizes what the heroes are doing. If the players are stuck, ladder the hints: first, wind visibly streams from the stones to the duck each time it leaps; then, any stray hit on a stone makes Duckleaf shriek and rush to defend it.

► **Duckleaf's tactics.** Wisdom (Perception) DC 12 reads its style: it opens with Aerial Slash from range, uses Winged Leap to skip away from melee without provoking, and saves its Quack of Fury (15 feet, Wisdom DC 14 or frightened) for when the party bunches up. It is a guardian, not a hunter: heroes who heed the warning and withdraw are allowed to leave, and if the fight turns badly it lets them retreat into the trees rather than pursue beyond the stones.

There is no talking their way past a guardian with a grudge and a leek. **Duckleaf** leaps from its stone and the wind leaps with it. It fights like a storm given feathers: riding gusts across the clearing, slashing with blades of sharpened air, loosing a *Quack of Fury* that rattles teeth and courage alike. But Stabby is faster than any wind, Ursa's magic finds it wherever it lands, and Lilly, watching the stones ripple, shouts the secret: *the circle is feeding it!* When the party disrupts one of the ancient stones, the gusts falter, and the duel turns.

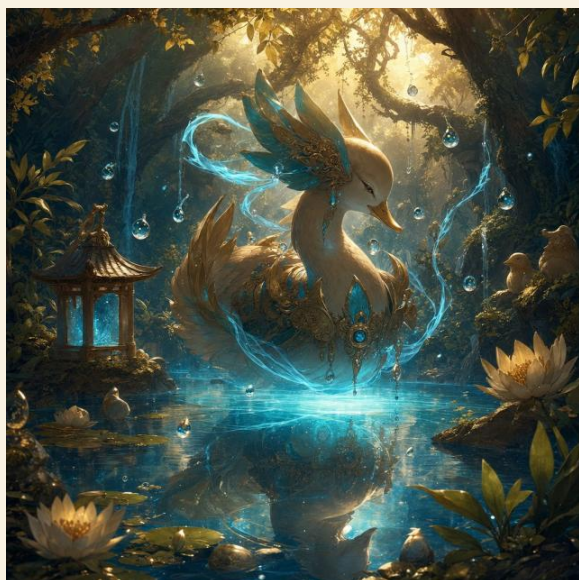
Beaten at last, Duckleaf sinks to the grass with one final, dignified quack. And then something strange: as the creature fades, a small **mote of energy** rises from it, faintly green, crackling with wind and light. It hovers a moment, warm to the touch, then slips away like a breeze through fingers. The whole clearing goes still.

Lilly, quietly: “That came from somewhere else. Something is leaking into our world.”

► **The motes.** Intelligence (Arcana) DC 14: each mote is a residue of another plane, left behind when a planar creature falls. Similar motes will rise from every such creature the party defeats; the pattern is the session's biggest clue to the doors opening between worlds.

The Grove of Elemental Waters

Deeper still, the ground turns soft and the sound of water leads the party to a hidden grove, where a wide pond glows a gentle blue from beneath, and droplets of water hang in the air, suspended as if time forgot them. Nothing here feels quite of this world.



The water stirs. From the center of the pond rises a duck like creature wrapped in pale blue light, hovering above its own reflection, eyes gleaming with psychic energy. The ripples spread from it in perfect rings, and its voice arrives not in the ears but behind them, calm and stern.

Cognifin: “You stand upon sacred ground. Prove your strength, or the waters will judge you.”

► **The guardian's test.** Cognifin, CR 3 (appendix). Intelligence (Arcana) or Wisdom (Nature) DC 14: it draws its strength from the pond itself, and disturbing the water's surface (a spell, a splash, a well-thrown rock) breaks its focus, silencing its whirlpools and tidal waves for a round.

Wisdom (Perception) DC 13: small whirlpools form and fade wherever it drifts, a telegraph of the water control to come.

► **Tactics.** It opens with Water Pulse to knock the closest hero prone, peppers the back line with Headache Blasts, and looses its Confusion Pulse when the party groups up; between turns its legendary waters pull heroes into whirlpools or shove them back with small tidal waves, while Psychic Shield turns away the worst blows. The test is stern but never lethal: a hero who drops is washed gently to the bank, unconscious but stable, and a party that falls or yields wakes at the grove's edge, free to try again once rested.

This one is no invader; it is a **guardian**, bound to test all who enter, and it fights like a slow, patient tide. Waves crash from a still pond. Whirlpools open where heroes stand. Psychic pressure squeezes like deep water. But the party fights as one now: Ursa's starlight, Lilly's sparks, Stabby laughing on the slick stones, Lickgloom yanking a friend back from a whirlpool with one heroic tongue.

When the guardian finally folds its light and yields, there is no anger in it. It bows its head, and a **mote of water energy** rises from the pond, pulsing soft and blue, before it too fades into the mist. The test is passed. The question it leaves behind is bigger than the grove: *who is opening the doors between worlds?*

◆ LORE OF ELARIA ◆ Motes

A mote is a crumb of another world, and the world it lands in treats it the way a pond treats a dropped lantern: strange light, strange ripples, and every fish in the pond suddenly having opinions. The wondrous creatures of the chronicle, the talking, glowing, impossible ones, are what happens when the ripples reach something alive.

Part Four: The Road to Oakshade

Carrying two mysteries and one new friend, the party pressed on through the forest's far side, toward the next village on the map.

The road to **Oakshade Village** winds through hills as the sun goes down, and with the dusk comes fog, thick and white and strange. Great gnarled roots have burst up through the packed earth of the road itself, as if something beneath the ground rolled over in its sleep. Shapes move in the murk.

► **Road hazards.** Dexterity (Acrobatics) DC 12 across the erupted roots, 1d4 bludgeoning on a stumble; Wisdom (Perception) DC 13 to hold the path in fog, and a party that strays gets ambushed on ground of the Stalkers' choosing.

► **The ambush.** Two **Mist Stalkers** (appendix). Each wraps itself in Fog Cloak to strike from heavy obscurement, and their Howl of the Mist rolls in from every direction at once, hunting for frightened, scattered prey. They will not leave their fog: heroes who regain the road and keep moving escape them, and a strong wind or a gust of magic that thins the mist steals their cover and their nerve.

They come with no sound at all: two sleek predators of fog and hunger, eyes like cold lamps, wearing the mist like a cloak. Their howls roll through the whiteness from every direction at once, hunting fear the way wolves hunt the slow. But this party does not scatter. Back to back around Lickgloom, blade and bolt and starlight answer the howling, until the mist runs thin and empties, and two motes of **fey energy** glimmer where the stalkers fell, swirling briefly before the fog swallows them.

The pattern is a pattern now. Every strange creature leaves a mote behind, a little piece of another plane, loose in the world.

Somewhere, doors are opening. The party walks the last miles wondering what is on the other side.



Twilight at Oakshade

Oakshade Village appears at last through the thinning fog, cottages nestled beneath oaks so old and vast the village seems built in their pockets. Lanterns glow gold in the windows. At the heart of the village square stands one ancient oak hung with faded ribbons and charms, an old well beside it, and the smell of woodsmoke and fresh bread on the air.

It should feel peaceful. It almost does. But the villagers walk quickly, and their eyes keep sliding to the forest's edge, as if the trees might follow them home.

Elder Merwin, the village's gray streaked blacksmith and elder, meets the party by his forge, sizing them up with a smith's eye for good material. "New faces in Oakshade, eh? Have not seen travelers since the forest started acting strange. The wind carries whispers, and folk

say they have seen creatures... things that do not belong here. The old stories talk of other realms, other planes. I never thought they would spill into our world.”

Next door, **Nina the herbalist** watches from the doorway of a little shop whose windows are crowded with dried herbs and potion bottles, the air around it sweet with lavender and sage. “There is magic in the air, stronger than usual,” she tells the party softly. “I can feel it in the plants and the water. And I have seen creatures near the village that are not in any of my books.”

◆ Provisions in Oakshade Village ◆

Merwin's Forge. Simple weapons (spear, shortsword, handaxe), arrows and bolts, chain shirts and shields at standard prices. Special: Merwin will silver a weapon for **100 gp**, good against certain fey and shadowy things.

Nina's Herbs and Remedies. Potion of Healing **50 gp**, antitoxin **25 gp**, herbal salves **5 gp**. Special: **Moonroot**, 75 gp, a rare herb Nina can brew into a potion that grants advantage on saving throws against being charmed.

The Old Oak Tavern. Hot stew, fresh bread, and cider; a warm room for the night is **5 silver** per person. A night here is a long rest.

In the warm little **Old Oak Tavern**, the keeper **Alwen** sets down bowls of hot stew unasked. “Well now, travelers! Made it just in time for dinner. Take a seat, and I will bring you a bowl.” Around the fire, villagers whisper of a glowing fox darting through the trees, and of old Merwin muttering that *the planes are bleeding together*.

The Missing Villagers

As the party finishes eating, Merwin comes to their table, and the smith's steadiness in his face has a crack of worry in it.

Merwin: “There is something I did not mention earlier. A few of our young folk went into the forest to gather herbs, days ago now. They have not come back. I have sent search parties and found nothing. If you are willing to look, you will have fifty gold and my gratitude, and Oakshade's with it.”

The party trades one look and agrees on the spot. But the search will wait for daylight. Tonight there are warm rooms above the tavern, and for the first time since three strangers collided at the Gilded Acorn, the new friends sleep under one roof: a gnome far from the deep places, a goblin far from his clan, a boy whose father watched these same stars, and one small fey creature dreaming, whatever fey creatures dream.



Oakshade Village at twilight, nestled beneath the ancient oaks.



Their first day together was done: a friendship, a brawl, two guardians bested, four motes of runaway magic, and a mystery with no bottom yet. In the morning, the search for the missing villagers would carry the Guardians of Elaria, though they did not yet know that name, deeper into the whispering wood, and toward a laboratory on the cliffs where an old elf kept watch on the doors between worlds.

Next: Session 2, in which lost villagers come home, a rival clan finds Stabby, a goddess opens her eyes inside a vision, and a professor's laboratory turns out to be full of impossible creatures.

APPENDIX

DM Run Sheet: The Day at a Glance

Every DC, dial, and spotlight, in play order. Keep this page at your elbow.

The Shape of the Session

► Four parts, four fights, one friend. P1 the Gilded Acorn (roleplay: three meetings, Osric and Rhea's rumors) → FIGHT 1, the brawl. P2 the Whispering Pond: Lickgloom (Perception DC 12 to spot it; Insight DC 10: playful, not a threat; Animal Handling DC 12 plus a snack = a companion). P3 the Forest of Whispers: FIGHT 2, Duckleaf at the stone circle → the first mote (Arcana DC 14) → FIGHT 3, Cognifin's test at the grove → the second mote. P4 the foggy road (roots: Acrobatics DC 12, 1d4 on a stumble; path: Perception DC 13 or ambushed on the Stalkers' ground): FIGHT 4, the Mist Stalkers → two fey motes → Oakshade (roleplay: Merwin, Nina, the shops) → the hook (missing villagers, 50 gp) → LONG REST at the Old Oak Tavern. Natural break point: the pond.

Fights at a Glance

FIGHT 1: The Bar Brawl (Easy; strictly non lethal). Bren (AC 12, HP 8, fists +3, 1d4 + 1) + 2x Regulars (AC 11, HP 6, fists +3, 1d4): brute force, ganging up on one or two heroes with fists, chairs, and one regrettable mug. Osric steps in if it gets too hot; a downed hero wakes in a minute with cider on the house.

FIGHT 2: The Stone Circle (Hard; the stones are the puzzle). Duckleaf (AC 15, HP 52, fly 30 ft; RESISTS slashing & bludgeoning): opens Aerial Slash +5 (3d6 + 3) at range, Winged Leap skips 30 ft out of melee without provoking, saves Quack of Fury (rech 5-6; 15 ft, DC 14 Wis, frightened) for a bunched party. THE RULE: disrupt one circle stone (Arcana or Nature DC 14 to see why) and Winged Leap is gone for the fight; ladder the hints if they stall. THE OUT: it is a guardian, not a hunter; heroes who withdraw are allowed to leave.

FIGHT 3: The Grove (Medium; stern, never lethal). Cognifin (AC 14, HP 45, hover; RESISTS cold & psychic; Psychic Shield reaction +2 AC): Water Pulse +4 (2d6 + 2, DC 12 Str or prone) on the closest hero, Headache Blast +4 (2d6 + 2 psychic) on the back line, Confusion Pulse (rech 5-6; 15 ft, DC 13 Wis) when they bunch; legendary waters between turns (whirlpool: DC 12 Str, restrained / tidal wave: 2d4, push 5 ft). THE RULE: disturbing the pond's surface (spell, splash, thrown rock) silences the legendary waters for a round. THE OUT: a dropped hero washes gently to the bank, stable; a beaten party wakes at the grove's edge, free to try again once rested.

FIGHT 4: The Foggy Road (Medium; fear is the weapon). 2x Mist Stalker (AC 13, HP 39, Speed 40 ft; Stealth +5): Fog Cloak (bonus action) for heavy obscurement, then bite +5 (1d8 + 3) and claw +5 (2d4 + 3); Howl of the Mist (rech 5-6; 30 ft, DC 13 Wis, frightened) rolls in from every direction at once. THE RULE: they will not leave their fog; a strong wind or a gust of magic thins the mist and steals their cover and their nerve. THE OUT: heroes who regain the road and keep moving escape them.

The Resource Picture

► Level 3, fresh, and no rest until Oakshade: the brawl costs nothing but pride, so the real spend is the forest. Duckleaf and Cognifin land back to back; watch Stabby's focus and Ursa's slots between them, and remember Cognifin's test cannot kill (a fallen hero washes ashore, stable). The Mist Stalkers hunt a tired party at dusk, and the frightened condition is the real drain in every fight, so celebrate the saves. The night at the Old Oak Tavern (5 silver a head) is a full long rest, and Oakshade sells the restock: Potion of Healing 50 gp, antitoxin 25 gp, Moonroot 75 gp, a silvered weapon for 100 gp, with Merwin's 50 gp bounty there to pay for it.

Spotlights & Seeds: every kid shines, every door gets planted

Lilly: her arrival opens the whole chronicle: the Essence Sphere and the name Ursa Catchum (Door: wake Pikachu) → the brawl: gadgets that spark and startle → the Duckleaf duel: she reads the rippling stones and shouts the secret (“the circle is feeding it!”) → after the mote, the session's thesis is hers: “Something is leaking into our world.”

Stabby: the BANG of the tavern door is his overture → the brawl is his stage: he fights like a rumor, everywhere and nowhere → faster than Duckleaf's wind, laughing on Cognifin's slick stones → seeds: the Bloodfang Clan and Master Kaelon in his introduction (Door: a rival clan, the Grimfang, catches up with him in Session 2).

Ursa: a stranger asking for him BY NAME pulls him in from the fields → one piece of bread wins the party its first friend → his starlight finds Duckleaf wherever it lands → seeds: Ash Catchum's disappearance and the three enchanted potatoes (Door: his father's trail), and the stars that have been waiting for this evening.

Foreshadow Tracker: say it, then say it again

► The tells, in order. Tavern hum x3 (Jarek's glow, strange winds, “the forest is waking up”) • Osric: “like they wandered in from... somewhere else” • Rhea: glowing eyes by the pond • wildflowers bloom out of season wherever Lickgloom walks • the MOTES, one per fallen planar creature: green wind (Duckleaf) → blue water (Cognifin) → twin fey glimmers (the Stalkers); Arcana DC 14 names the pattern • Merwin: “the planes are bleeding together” • the missing villagers: Session 2 walks in the door.

APPENDIX

Bestiary: Enemy Stat Blocks

All four encounters of Session 1, in the order the party meets them, plus one friend made along the way.

ENEMIES, Fight 1: The Bar Brawl

The Gilded Acorn ♦ Difficulty: Easy ♦ 1x Bren + 2x Regulars

BREN, THE ROWDY LOCAL

Medium humanoid ♦ bandit stats, softened for a friendly brawl



AC 12 HP 8 Speed 30 ft

Traits

Non Lethal Brawler. All of Bren's damage is non lethal. A hero reduced to 0 HP wakes a minute later with a bruised ear and a mug of cider on the house.

Actions

Unarmed Strike. *Melee Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 1d4 + 1 bludgeoning damage (a fist, a chair, or one regrettable mug).

TAVERN REGULAR

Medium humanoid ♦ bandit stats, softened ♦ 2 in the brawl



AC 11 HP 6 Speed 30 ft

Traits

Non Lethal Brawler. All damage in the brawl is non lethal; a downed hero wakes a minute later, embarrassed but unhurt.

Actions

Unarmed Strike. *Melee Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 1d4 bludgeoning damage.

Tactics: Bren and his friends are not skilled fighters; they rely on brute force, ganging up on one or two heroes at a time. Strictly non lethal: fists, chairs, and one regrettable mug. Waving Bren off only makes him louder, so let the fight come to the table, and have Osric step in if things get too hot. The point of the scene is three strangers fighting together for the first time, and winning.

♦ LORE OF ELARIA ♦ The Vale Villages

The villages of Eldridge Vale were founded by families who followed the Warden's star west until it set behind friendly hills, then stopped. Every village in the vale still builds its tavern first and its walls never, which tells you everything about the thousand years the vale has had.

ALLIES: Lickgloom

The Whispering Pond ♦ Befriended with bread and patience ♦ Fey companion

LICKGLOOM

Small fey (Feywild), neutral ♦ CR 1 (200 XP)

AC 13 (natural armor) **HP** 27 (5d6 + 10) **Speed** 30 ft

STR 14 **DEX** 12 **CON** 14 **INT** 6 **WIS** 10 **CHA** 8

Saves Dex +3 **Skills** Perception +2, Stealth +4

Resist acid, poison

Senses darkvision 60 ft, passive Perception 12

Languages understands Common but cannot speak; telepathic impressions

Challenge 1 (200 XP)

Traits

Helpful Tongue. Traveling with the party, Lickgloom can fetch small objects with its 10 foot tongue, and once per scene its tasting tongue grants one hero advantage on a Wisdom (Perception) or Intelligence (Investigation) check.

Actions

Tongue Whip. *Melee Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 10 ft. *Hit:* 1d6 + 2 bludgeoning damage, and the target must succeed on a DC 12 Strength saving throw or be grappled (escape DC 12).

Sticky Lick (Recharge 5-6). One creature within 10 ft must succeed on a DC 13 Dexterity saving throw or lose one small item (a weapon, potion, or trinket), which Lickgloom pulls to itself.

Lick Attack. *Melee Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 1d8 + 2 bludgeoning damage, and the target must succeed on a DC 12 Constitution saving throw or be stunned until the end of its next turn.



Tactics: Not an enemy: curious, playful, and hungry for new tastes. It meets aggression by darting into the pond, and it meets bread by joining the party. In a fight it stays behind its friends and helps how it can; at the grove it hauled a hero out of a whirlpool with one heroic tongue.

ENEMIES, Fight 2: The Stone Circle

The Forest of Whispers ♦ Difficulty: Hard ♦ 1x Duckleaf, guardian of the circle

DUCKLEAF

Small beast (Elemental Air), neutral ♦ CR 4 (1,100 XP)

AC 15 (natural armor) **HP** 52 (8d8 + 16) **Speed** 30 ft, fly 30 ft

STR 14 **DEX** 16 **CON** 14 **INT** 10 **WIS** 12 **CHA** 10

Saves Dex +5, Wis +3 **Skills** Acrobatics +5, Perception +3

Resist slashing, bludgeoning (wind sheath)

Senses darkvision 60 ft, passive Perception 13

Languages telepathy 30 ft (quacks)

Challenge 4 (1,100 XP)

Traits

Winged Leap. Duckleaf can leap 30 ft in any direction without provoking opportunity attacks, riding the wind to evade and reposition. If a stone of the circle is damaged or disrupted, it loses this trait for the rest of the battle.

Actions

Leek Strike. *Melee Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 2d8 + 4 slashing damage, the wind guiding the blow with deadly accuracy.

Aerial Slash. *Ranged Attack:* +5 to hit, range 20/60 ft. *Hit:* 3d6 + 3 slashing damage from a blade of sharpened air.

Quack of Fury (Recharge 5-6). A telepathic quack reverberates through the clearing. Each creature within 15 ft must succeed on a DC 14 Wisdom saving throw or be frightened for 1 minute; a frightened creature repeats the save at the end of each of its turns.



Tactics: It opens with Aerial Slash from range, uses Winged Leap to skip away from melee without provoking, and saves Quack of Fury for a bunched-up party. The circle is the fight: wind visibly streams from the stones to the duck each time it leaps, and disrupting one stone grounds it; it defends the stones fiercely once it realizes what the heroes are doing. A guardian, not a hunter: heroes who heed the warning may withdraw, and it never pursues beyond the stones.

♦ LORE OF ELARIA ♦ The Stone Rings

The standing stones scattered across the vales are older than every road. Each ring was raised where a plane leans close to the world, and each was given a guardian, feathered, finned, or worse, to keep the leaning from becoming a fall.

ENEMIES, Fight 3: The Grove of Elemental Waters

The Forest of Whispers ♦ Difficulty: Medium ♦ 1x Cognifin, the guardian's test

COGNIFIN

Small beast (Elemental Water), neutral guardian ♦ CR 3 (700 XP)

AC 14 (natural armor) **HP** 45 (6d8 + 18) **Speed** 0 ft, fly 30 ft (hover)

STR 10 **DEX** 14 **CON** 16 **INT** 10 **WIS** 14 **CHA** 12

Saves Dex +4, Wis +4 **Skills** Perception +4, Arcana +2

Resist cold, psychic

Senses darkvision 60 ft, passive Perception 14

Languages telepathy 60 ft (images and feelings)

Challenge 3 (700 XP)

Actions

Headache Blast. *Ranged Attack:* +4 to hit, range 30 ft. *Hit:* 2d6 + 2 psychic damage, a crush of pressure inside the mind.

Water Pulse. *Ranged Attack:* +4 to hit, range 30 ft. *Hit:* 2d6 + 2 bludgeoning damage, and the target must succeed on a DC 12 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone by the crashing wave.

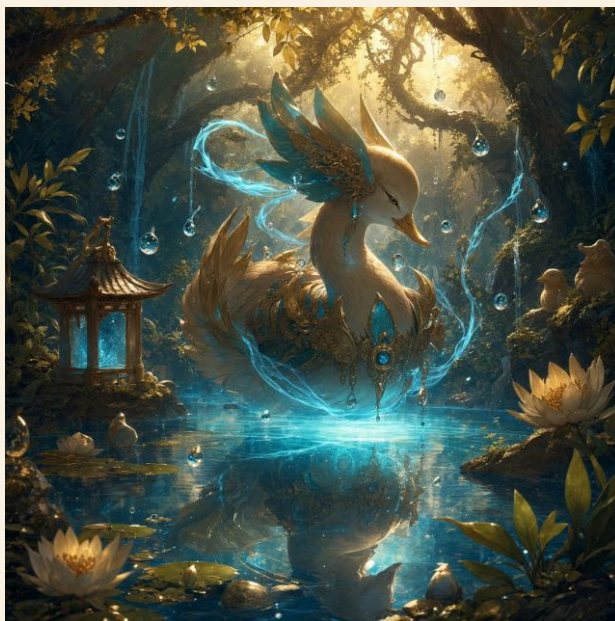
Confusion Pulse (Recharge 5-6). A wave of psychic energy in a 15 ft radius. Each creature in the area must succeed on a DC 13 Wisdom saving throw or be confused (as the confusion spell) for 1 minute; repeat the save at the end of each turn.

Reactions

Psychic Shield. When hit by an attack, Cognifin raises a shimmering barrier, gaining +2 AC until the start of its next turn.

Legendary Actions

Waters of the Grove. At the end of any hero's turn, Cognifin commands the pond: **Whirlpool** (5 ft radius; DC 12 Strength save or be pulled 10 ft to the center and restrained until the end of its next turn) or **Tidal Wave** (10 ft line; DC 12 Dexterity save or take 2d4 bludgeoning damage and be pushed back 5 ft).



Tactics: It opens with *Water Pulse* to knock the closest hero prone, peppers the back line with *Headache Blasts*, and looses *Confusion Pulse* when the party groups up, while its legendary waters pull heroes into whirlpools or shove them back between turns. Disturbing the pond's surface (a spell, a splash, a well-thrown rock) breaks its focus and silences the waters for a round. The test is stern but never lethal: a hero who drops is washed gently to the bank, stable, and a party that falls or yields wakes at the grove's edge, free to try again once rested.

ENEMIES, Fight 4: The Foggy Road

The Road to Oakshade ♦ Difficulty: Medium ♦ 2x Mist Stalker

MIST STALKER

Medium fey (Feywild), unaligned ♦ CR 2 (450 XP) ♦ 2 in the ambush

AC 13 **HP** 39 (6d8 + 12) **Speed** 40 ft

STR 14 **DEX** 16 **CON** 14 **INT** 6 **WIS** 12 **CHA** 8

Skills Perception +3, Stealth +5

Senses darkvision 60 ft, passive Perception 13

Challenge 2 (450 XP)

Traits

Fog Cloak (Bonus Action). The stalker wraps itself in mist, becoming heavily obscured until the start of its next turn.

Actions

Multiattack. The mist stalker makes one bite attack and one claw attack.

Bite. *Melee Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 1d8 + 3 piercing damage.

Claw. *Melee Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 2d4 + 3 slashing damage.

Howl of the Mist (Recharge 5-6). A howl rolls through the fog from every direction at once. Each enemy within 30 ft must succeed on a DC 13 Wisdom saving throw or be frightened until the end of the stalker's next turn.



Tactics: Each stalker wraps itself in Fog Cloak and strikes from heavy obscurement, and their howls hunt for frightened, scattered prey. They will not leave their fog: heroes who regain the road and keep moving escape them, and a strong wind or a gust of magic that thins the mist steals their cover and their nerve. Two motes of fey energy glimmer where they fall.